

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Legal Operations and Compliance English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For legal operations staff, compliance managers, contract managers, policy owners, audit teams, investigation coordinators, privacy operations staff, and risk professionals.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

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Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Contract intake

02 Policy into a control

03 Audit evidence gap

04 Investigation intake

05 Privacy request routing

06 Third-party due diligence

07 Training attestation

08 Risk committee reporting

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Contract intake

Legal operations clarifies an incomplete request.

Roles: Legal operations coordinator / Business requester

Legal operations coordinator: Before we assign the contract, we need the counterparty, value, deadline, and business purpose.

Business requester: The sales team asked for a review today, but I haven't received the latest draft.

Legal operations coordinator: Please obtain the current version and explain the reason for the requested date.

Business requester: I'll also identify the business owner and any nonstandard terms already discussed.

Legal operations coordinator: Then we can triage it using the actual risk and workload.

Business requester: I'll tell the team the review is requested, not completed or guaranteed for today.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Before we assign the contract, we need the counterparty, value, deadline, and business purpose." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Policy into a control

Compliance and operations implement a new requirement.

Roles: Compliance manager / Process owner

Compliance manager: The policy is approved. What control will show that the process actually follows it?

Process owner: A documented review before release, with a named reviewer and retained evidence.

Compliance manager: Define the population, frequency, exception route, and records needed.

Process owner: I'll map those to the workflow and check that the team has capacity.

Compliance manager: We'll test the design before treating the control as operating effectively.

Process owner: I'll prepare a sample case so we can check the process and evidence together.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The policy is approved. What control will show that the process actually follows it?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Audit evidence gap

A control owner responds to an audit request.

Roles: Internal auditor / Compliance analyst

Internal auditor: The attestation says all cases were reviewed, but the evidence covers only the sampled cases.

Compliance analyst: I'll clarify whether the control requires full-population review or sampling, and provide the approved methodology.

Internal auditor: Good. The statement should match what was actually done.

Compliance analyst: I'll preserve the existing records and identify any unsupported claim.

Internal auditor: We'll assess the gap and agree on the appropriate reporting and follow-up.

Compliance analyst: I'll record an owner and due date for each authorized corrective action.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The attestation says all cases were reviewed, but the evidence covers only the sampled cases." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Investigation intake

A compliance coordinator prepares an allegation summary.

Roles: Investigation coordinator / Legal counsel

Investigation coordinator: The manager wants the summary to call this a confirmed policy violation.

Legal counsel: Has the investigation reached that finding, or are we still recording an allegation?

Investigation coordinator: Still an allegation. We have an interview account and documents requiring review.

Legal counsel: Use neutral wording and follow the approved investigation and confidentiality process.

Investigation coordinator: I'll separate reported information, observed evidence, and unanswered questions.

Legal counsel: I'll review the scope and next steps without treating an initial report as a final conclusion.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Has the investigation reached that finding, or are we still recording an allegation?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Privacy request routing

Operations receives a request concerning personal data.

Roles: Privacy operations analyst / System owner

Privacy operations analyst: We received a request relating to personal data in your system. We need to identify the relevant records through the approved process.

System owner: Should my team send a complete export directly to the requester?

Privacy operations analyst: No. Verification, scope, applicable rights, and disclosure review need coordination first.

System owner: I'll map the systems and retention arrangements without transmitting unnecessary data.

Privacy operations analyst: I'll confirm the authorized search and response requirements with the privacy team.

System owner: We'll preserve the records and provide the required information through the designated channel.

Notice the professional language

personal data - Information relating to an identified or identifiable person under the relevant legal definition.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Third-party due diligence

A compliance team reviews a proposed intermediary.

Roles: Business development manager / Compliance reviewer

Business development manager: The intermediary can help us enter the market quickly. Can we sign while due diligence continues?

Compliance reviewer: We need to follow the applicable approval process and assess any conditions before committing.

Business development manager: Their ownership information is incomplete, but they say it's commercially sensitive.

Compliance reviewer: Document the gap and seek the required information through the review process.

Business development manager: I'll explain that the assessment is pending and avoid promising an exception.

Compliance reviewer: I'll identify the remaining questions and route the risk decision to the authorized reviewers.

Notice the professional language

due diligence - Structured review of facts, risks, obligations, and evidence before a transaction, onboarding, investment, or decision.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Training attestation

A policy owner questions what a completion figure means.

Roles: Policy owner / Learning coordinator

Policy owner: The dashboard says 98 percent completed training. Does that establish understanding?

Learning coordinator: It establishes the recorded completion measure. Understanding and application require other evidence.

Policy owner: We also need to check who is missing from the assigned population.

Learning coordinator: I'll reconcile the roster and distinguish incomplete assignments from data errors.

Policy owner: Let's review the knowledge checks and questions staff are raising.

Learning coordinator: I'll prepare that evidence so we can target follow-up rather than rely only on a completion percentage.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The dashboard says 98 percent completed training. Does that establish understanding?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Risk committee reporting

A compliance lead prepares a risk update.

Roles: Compliance lead / Risk committee secretary

Compliance lead: This issue is marked closed because the new procedure was approved, but effectiveness hasn't been tested.

Risk committee secretary: Separate implementation from evidence that the control works.

Compliance lead: I'll report the actual stage, residual uncertainty, and the planned effectiveness review.

Risk committee secretary: Include the decision or oversight you need from the committee.

Compliance lead: I'll identify the accountable owner and any overdue dependencies.

Risk committee secretary: Then the minutes can record the committee's actual decision rather than imply closure from discussion alone.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "This issue is marked closed because the new procedure was approved, but effectiveness hasn't been tested." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Contract Intake and Workflow

SHARED CASE

A contract intake request says "urgent" but omits the agreement type, business owner, and required decision date.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you confirm the agreement type, business owner, and reason for the requested date? That will help the team route and prioritize the request using the actual business need.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Policy Implementation and Controls

SHARED CASE

A policy has been published, but nobody has identified who performs the related check or keeps the evidence.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Publishing the policy is one step. We also need to identify who performs the check, how often, and where its evidence is recorded so the process can operate consistently.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Compliance Audits and Evidence

SHARED CASE

An auditor requests records for a specific period. A team proposes sending a current screenshot with no date context.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we provide evidence covering the requested period and identify its source? A current screenshot alone may not answer the historical question in the request.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Internal Investigations

SHARED CASE

A hotline report contains an allegation and the reporter's interpretation. The intake note presents both as established facts.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'll distinguish the reported event from the reporter's interpretation and use neutral wording. The investigation process should establish findings; the intake note should not prejudge them.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Privacy Operations and Data Requests

SHARED CASE

A data request arrives with insufficient information to identify the requester or scope. Staff are unsure which workflow applies.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we confirm the request type and required verification through the privacy process? Let's identify the relevant information without assuming access or disclosure is already authorized.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Third-Party Risk and Due Diligence

SHARED CASE

Two vendors offer similar services. One handles more personal data and relies on additional subcontractors.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

The service descriptions are similar, but the data handling differs. I'll make those differences visible in the due-diligence summary so the responsible team can assess the relevant risks and controls.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Training, Attestations, and Culture

SHARED CASE

Training completion is 98%, but employees still ask how to apply the policy to common situations.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Completion shows attendance or participation, not necessarily practical understanding. Let's add role-specific scenarios and check whether people can identify the appropriate action in their work.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Governance, Reporting, and Risk Committees

SHARED CASE

A risk committee tracker shows an action as complete because its plan was approved. Implementation evidence is still outstanding.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

The plan is approved; implementation is not yet verified. I'll report those stages separately and identify the evidence needed before the committee treats the action as complete.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Courts: glossary of legal terms

<https://www.uscourts.gov/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.